

Digital

[NHS Digital \(Link: /\)](#) [Services \(Link: /services\)](#) [Reasonable Adjustment Flag](#)

Reasonable Adjustment Flag

The Reasonable Adjustment Flag is part of the Patient Flags Service. It is a national record that shows a person needs accommodations and may include details about their impairments and necessary adjustments.

Patients and carers

To find out more about the provision of reasonable adjustments, visit the [Reasonable adjustments for people with a learning disability \(Link: https://www.gov.uk/government/collections/reasonable-adjustments-for-people-with-a-learning-disability\)](https://www.gov.uk/government/collections/reasonable-adjustments-for-people-with-a-learning-disability) page on GOV.UK or contact the organisations that are providing your care.

About this service

Health and social care
workers

Under the [Equality Act 2010 \(Link: http://www.gov.uk/guidance/equality-act-2010-guidance\)](http://www.gov.uk/guidance/equality-act-2010-guidance), organisations have a legal duty to make changes in their approach or provision to ensure that services are as accessible to people with disabilities as they are for everybody else. These changes are called reasonable adjustments.

The Reasonable Adjustment Flag was developed in the [NHS Spine \(Link: /services/spine\)](/services/spine) to enable health and care workers to record, share and view details of reasonable adjustments across the NHS, wherever the person is treated.

The capability is now available on the [National Care Records Service \(NCRS\) \(Link: /services/national-care-records-service\)](/services/national-care-records-service).

A Fast Healthcare Interoperability Resources (FHIR) software interface is available for API-based integration with local point-of-care applications.

Benefits

- The Flag is immediately visible (to reception staff, as permitted by local role-based access controls) when the patient is referred or presents for care, often when no other information is available.
 - It will ensure that details of impairments and other key information (such as communication requirements) are shared consistently across the NHS – with patient consent.
 - Supports carers to feel less stressed by informing them of adjustments to services.
 - It can help to reduce stress both for the patient and those treating them.
 - Specialist teams will be able to set the Flag – driving up the number of patients recorded on registers, who are identified for and can benefit from adjustments. This will help screening services to adapt services to ensure patients receive screening.
 - It satisfies legal obligations under the Equality Act 2010 and NHS contracts and as defined in the [NHS Long Term Plan \(Link: https://www.longtermplan.nhs.uk/\)](https://www.longtermplan.nhs.uk/).
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Who this service is for

This service is for health and social care workers in any care setting who are treating patients that require reasonable adjustments, ensuring their needs are considered and catered for.

This service is only for use in England, and only for the purpose of direct care.

It does not have a user interface - users must access it indirectly via the [National Care Records Service \(NCRS\) \(Link: /services/national-care-records-service\)](/services/national-care-records-service).

A Fast Healthcare Interoperability Resources (FHIR) software interface is available for API-based integration with local point-of-care applications.

What information is available

The Flag is designed to provide staff with information on their duties under the Equality Act 2010. It lists existing adjustments, defined by clinical codes – such as [communication needs defined using the Accessible Information Standard clinical codes \(Link: https://www.england.nhs.uk/long-read/accessible-information-standard-implementation-guidance/\)](https://www.england.nhs.uk/long-read/accessible-information-standard-implementation-guidance/) - as well as the opportunity to create highly individualised bespoke adjustments for patients.

Who is included

The service holds records for all patients in England who have been flagged as needing reasonable adjustments. A record is created for a patient when a health or social care worker first records the patient's reasonable adjustments.

What information is held for each patient

The Flag provides:

- basic context about a patient
- key adjustments and the details related to this
- further information to aid health and care workers

This legal duty is anticipatory which means a service should know about a person's need for adjustments when they are referred or present for care. For this to happen, and for optimum care to be delivered, adjustments need to be recorded and shared across the NHS.

The Flag can also record if a patient meets the Equality Act definition of disability - the code is:

- "Impairment with substantial and long-term adverse effect on normal day to day activity (Equality Act 2010)"

It can also optionally contain details of the disability or long term condition that is the source of the [patient's impairment\(s\) in line with the Equality Act 2010 \(Link: http://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/570382/Equality_Act_2010_disability_definition.pdf\)](http://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/570382/Equality_Act_2010_disability_definition.pdf).

The impairment type list shows the impairment types that can be recorded. The Harmonised Impairment Standard enables the consistent, high profile and routine recording of impairment (including the option of 'prefer not to say').

Impairment types

Vision - for example blindness or partial sight

Hearing - for example deafness or partial hearing

Mobility - for example walking short distances or climbing stairs

Dexterity - for example lifting and carrying objects, using a keyboard

Learning or understanding or concentrating

Memory

Mental health

Stamina or breathing or fatigue

Social and/or communication differences (for example, associated with Autism and Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder - ADHD)

Other (please specify)

Prefer not to say

Categories and types of adjustments

Examples of the categories of adjustments, and the types of adjustments within them, that can be recorded on the Flag, are:

Accessible information - communications support

Accessible information - requires communications professional

Accessible information - requires specific contact method

Accessible information - requires specific information format

Additional communications support

Community language support

Additional support

Individual care requirements

Adjustments to the environment

Bespoke reasonable adjustments

Impairment and Reasonable Adjustment codes

National usage policy

This service is mandated for use in all care settings in England.

This is based on:

- the Equality Act 2010 (Link: <http://www.gov.uk/guidance/equality-act-2010-guidance>)
- the NHS Long Term Plan (Link: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/10-year-health-plan-for-england-fit-for-the-future>)

For details on the suppliers who have registered their interest in the Reasonable Adjustments Flags, see the [Reasonable Adjustments Flags supplier interest list page](#) (Link: </services/reasonable-adjustment-flag/reasonable-adjustments-flags-supplier-interest-list>).

Examples of use

Recording of impairments - details of disability or long term condition

A Reasonable Adjustment Flag is typically created by a GP, but can also be created by a range of health and care professionals including nurses and therapists from learning disability teams.

The Reasonable Adjustment Flag considers a range of adjustments and requirements for patients, including:

- a deaf patient who requires a communication device or BSL speaker
- a patient who is anxious in clinical settings and therefore may need additional considerations to keep them calm
- a patient who is sensitive to loud noises and would be more comfortable in a low noise environment
- alterations to buildings by providing lifts, wide doors, ramps for those who need an accessible way to access a service
- changes to policies, procedures and staff training to ensure that services work for people with physical or sensory disabilities, learning disabilities or long-term conditions such as dementia

Case study - reasonable adjustments for Jamie

ARTICLE

Reasonable Adjustment Flag case study (based on pilot version of the flag)

An example of a flag that can be created in the system using a theoretical case study built around stakeholder feedback and the learning from the flag pilots.

(Link: </services/reasonable-adjustment-flag/reasonable-adjustment-flag-case-study>)

How this service works

The Flag is part of the [NHS Spine](#) (Link: </services/spine>) and healthcare professionals and administrative staff can view, create, add or remove information from the Flag. This can be done using the [National Care Records Service](#) (Link: <https://digital.nhs.uk/services/national-care-records-service>) (NCRS). A Fast Healthcare Interoperability Resources (FHIR) software interface is also available for clinical systems to integrate directly with the Flag.

Access is controlled via [NHS smartcards](#) (Link: <https://digital.nhs.uk/services/registration-authorities-and-smartcards>) and the appropriate Role Based Access Codes (RBAC), so that only authorised healthcare professionals and administrative staff with the relevant security permissions can access the information in the Reasonable Adjustment Flag. Administrative staff who only access demographics information on the spine can clearly see the presence of the Flag but not the information within it.

Health and care organisations create the Flag in conjunction with the individual and/or their carer or in line with existing best interest decision processes.

How to create a Flag

This guidance takes you through how to create and view reasonable adjustments on the NHS Spine.

ARTICLE

Guide to Using the Reasonable Adjustment Flag in NCRS

This user guide is intended for all users of the Reasonable Adjustments feature in the National Care Records Service (NCRS). It explains how to create a Reasonable Adjustment flag and when it is appropriate to do so. Guidance is also provided for viewing, updating, and deleting a Reasonable Adjustments flag.

(Link: </services/reasonable-adjustment-flag/guide-to-using-the-reasonable-adjustment-flag-in-ncrs>)

[Health and care professionals and supporting staff](#)

[Professional and other related bodies](#)

[Care networks and related organisations](#)

[Government and related public sector organisations](#)

[Patient related organisations](#)

Status, service level and current usage

This service is **live** ([Link: /services/reference-guide#status](#)). It has been live since 2019, and has seen wider adoption since its inclusion in the National Care Records Service in 2023.

It is a **bronze** ([Link: /services/reference-guide#service-levels](#)) service, meaning it is supported between 8am and 6pm Monday to Friday excluding bank holidays.

Roadmap

Work is being undertaken leading to first of type direct integration of the Reasonable Adjustment Flag via the Patient Flags API with clinical systems. This will complement the current functionality available in NCRS and lay the groundwork for wider adoption of the Reasonable Adjustment Flag across the NHS. Current expectation is that this work on integration will be completed by early 2025, after which the capability will be made available for wider use in systems across health and care.

April to June 2026

- Commence onboarding the GP suppliers to Reasonable Adjustments Flag read and write capability
- GP Suppliers to commence the bulk upload of their locally Reasonable Adjustments to allow for national sharing of Reasonable Adjustments
- Allow onboarding to Reasonable Adjustments Flag for all suppliers integrating for read capability
- Continue to raise awareness of the Reasonable Adjustments Flag and encourage suppliers to register their interest to integrate

January to March 2026

- Commence first of type integration for write functionality
 - Onboard Fast Followers to Reasonable Adjustments Flag for all suppliers integrating for read capability
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Change history

In this section you can find project milestones that the service reached in previous years.

2025

- The Access Group go live with Reasonable Adjustments Flag - Read capability
- Working with our GPIT team to have patient flags added to the GP system suppliers roadmaps
- Product adoption to support suppliers to onboard and meet full conformance 150 systems registered interest in integrating the Reasonable Adjustments Flag
- Integration with the Multi-cast notification service (MNS) for local flag synchronisation

2024

- Developed Patient Flags API for Reasonable Adjustments
- Reasonable Adjustment Flag via the Patient Flag API went live in National Care Record Service (NCRS)
- Commenced first of type activities for read functionality
- Commenced engagement with suppliers and service users for integration of the Reasonable Adjustment Flag

How to access this service

The Flag is part of the [NHS Spine \(Link: /services/spine\)](/services/spine) and healthcare professionals and administrative staff can view, create, add or remove information from the Flag. This can be done using the [National Care Records Service \(Link: /services/national-care-records-service\)](/services/national-care-records-service) (NCRS). A Fast Healthcare Interoperability Resources (FHIR) software interface is also available for clinical systems to integrate directly with the Flag.

Access is controlled via [NHS smartcards \(Link: /services/care-identity-service/registration-authority-users\)](/services/care-identity-service/registration-authority-users) and the appropriate Role Based Access Codes (RBAC), so that only authorised healthcare professionals and administrative staff with the relevant security permissions can access the information in the Reasonable Adjustment Flag. Administrative staff who only access demographics information on the spine can clearly see the presence of the Flag but not the information within it.

Health and care organisations create the Flag in conjunction with the individual and/or their carer or in line with existing best interest decision processes.

Contact us

Enquiry

Live service incident

Contact

National Service Desk

Email: ssd.nationalservicedesk@nhs.net (Link: <mailto:ssd.nationalservicedesk@nhs.net>)Report via our customer portal (Link: <https://www.support.digitalservices.nhs.uk/csm>)

Telephone: 0300 303 5035

Enquiry

General enquiries

Contact

Enquiries team

Email: enquiries@nhsdigital.nhs.uk (Link: <mailto:enquiries@nhsdigital.nhs.uk>)

Enquiry

Strategic direction and escalations

Contact

Shan Rahulan

Email: shan.rahulan@nhs.net (Link: <mailto:shan.rahulan@nhs.net>)

Related services

Service

[National Care Records Service \(NCRS\) \(Link: /services/national-care-records-service\)](/services/national-care-records-service)

Relationship

National point-of-care application allows healthcare workers to manage patient information for Reasonable Adjustments.

Recommended training resources

National training resources are available on reasonable adjustments, including where they apply and how they support patient care. A selection of useful links is provided below. This is not an exhaustive list.

ARTICLE

elearning for healthcare (elfh) - Reasonable Adjustments Digital Flag Training

NHSE elearning for healthcare (elfh) is an NHS England programme providing over 500 interactive, online training sessions to support the health and social care workforce. There is a section dedicated to information about the Reasonable Adjustment Flag.

(Link: <https://www.e-lfh.org.uk/programmes/reasonable-adjustment-digital-flag/>)

ARTICLE

The Oliver McGowan Mandatory Training on Learning Disability and Autism

The Oliver McGowan Mandatory Training on Learning Disability and Autism is the government's preferred and recommended training for health and social care staff. Oliver McGowan was a young man whose death shone a light on the need for health and social care staff to have better skills, knowledge and understanding of the needs for autistic people and people with a learning disability.

(Link: <https://www.e-lfh.org.uk/programmes/the-oliver-mcgowan-mandatory-training-on-learning-disability-and-autism/>)

ARTICLE

Reasonable Adjustment Flag in NCRS

Guidance on how to use the Reasonable Adjustment Flag in the National Care Record Service (NCRS).

(Link: </services/national-care-records-service/guidance/reasonable-adjustment-flag>)

ARTICLE

NHS Futures Reasonable Adjustment Digital Flag workspace

A free, secure collaboration and learning environment used across health and care in England. Within Future NHS there are dedicated workspaces and resources on the Reasonable Adjustment Digital Flag, including practical examples, discussions, tools and a short e-learning module on reasonable adjustments and how the digital flag works.

(Link: <https://future.nhs.uk/system/login?nextURL=%2Fconnect%2Eti%2FNationalReasonableAdjustmentFlag>)

NHS Futures

Note - you can only register for a NHS Futures account if you have received an invitation email to join a workspace or you have a @nhs.net, @nhs.uk or @gov.uk email address.

If you would like to join the NHS Futures Reasonable Adjustment workspace and don't have one of the above email addresses please email england.radfproject@nhs.net (Link: <mailto:england.radfproject@nhs.net>).

Further information

NHS England reasonable adjustments information for NHS staff (Link: <https://www.england.nhs.uk/learning-disabilities/improving-health/reasonable-adjustments/>)

How can I help make sure these adjustments are made? Including what digital flagging means for patients a short film is about how sharing information can help staff in health services know the right way to work with people with a learning disability and/or autism.

Reasonable adjustments for people with a learning disability (Link: <https://www.gov.uk/government/collections/reasonable-adjustments-for-people-with-a-learning-disability>)

Public Health England Guides on how reasonable adjustments should be made to health services and adjustments to help people with learning disabilities to access services.

Making reasonable adjustments (Link:

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/656258/Social_care_staff

Social care guidance about making reasonable adjustments for people with learning disabilities.

The confidential inquiry into premature deaths of people with learning disabilities (Link:

<http://www.bristol.ac.uk/cipold/reports/>

The inquiry found: 1) The lack of reasonable adjustments ... was a contributory factor in a number of deaths. 2) GP referrals commonly did not mention learning disabilities, and hospital 'flagging' systems to identify people with learning disabilities who needed reasonable adjustments were limited. 3) There is a need for clear identification of people with learning disabilities on the NHS central registration system and for this information to be made available to care professionals in healthcare record systems. Merely identifying that a person has learning disabilities is not sufficient - this information needs to be supplemented by a statement of the reasonable adjustments required.

Equality Act 2010 guidance (Link: <https://www.gov.uk/definition-of-disability-under-equality-act-2010>)

Equality and Human Rights Commission guidance on the Equality Act 2010.

Definition of disability under the Equality Act 2010 (Link: <https://www.gov.uk/definition-of-disability-under-equality-act-2010>)

You're disabled under the Equality Act 2010 if you have a physical or mental impairment that has a 'substantial' and 'long-term' negative effect on your ability to do normal daily activities.

Accessible Information Standard (Link: <https://www.england.nhs.uk/long-read/accessible-information-standard-implementation-guidance>)

All organisations that provide NHS or adult social care must follow the accessible information standard by law. The standard aims to make sure that people who have a disability, impairment or sensory loss are provided with information that they can easily read or understand with support so they can communicate effectively with health and social care services.

Reasonable Adjustment Flag: GDPR information (Link: </data-and-information/keeping-data-safe-and-benefitting-the-public/gdpr/gdpr-register/reasonable-adjustments-flag>)

Why and how we process your data in the Reasonable Adjustment Flag and your rights.

NHS Long Term Plan (Link: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/10-year-health-plan-for-england-fit-for-the-future>)

By 2023/24, a 'digital flag' in the patient record will ensure staff know a patient has a learning disability or autism.

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